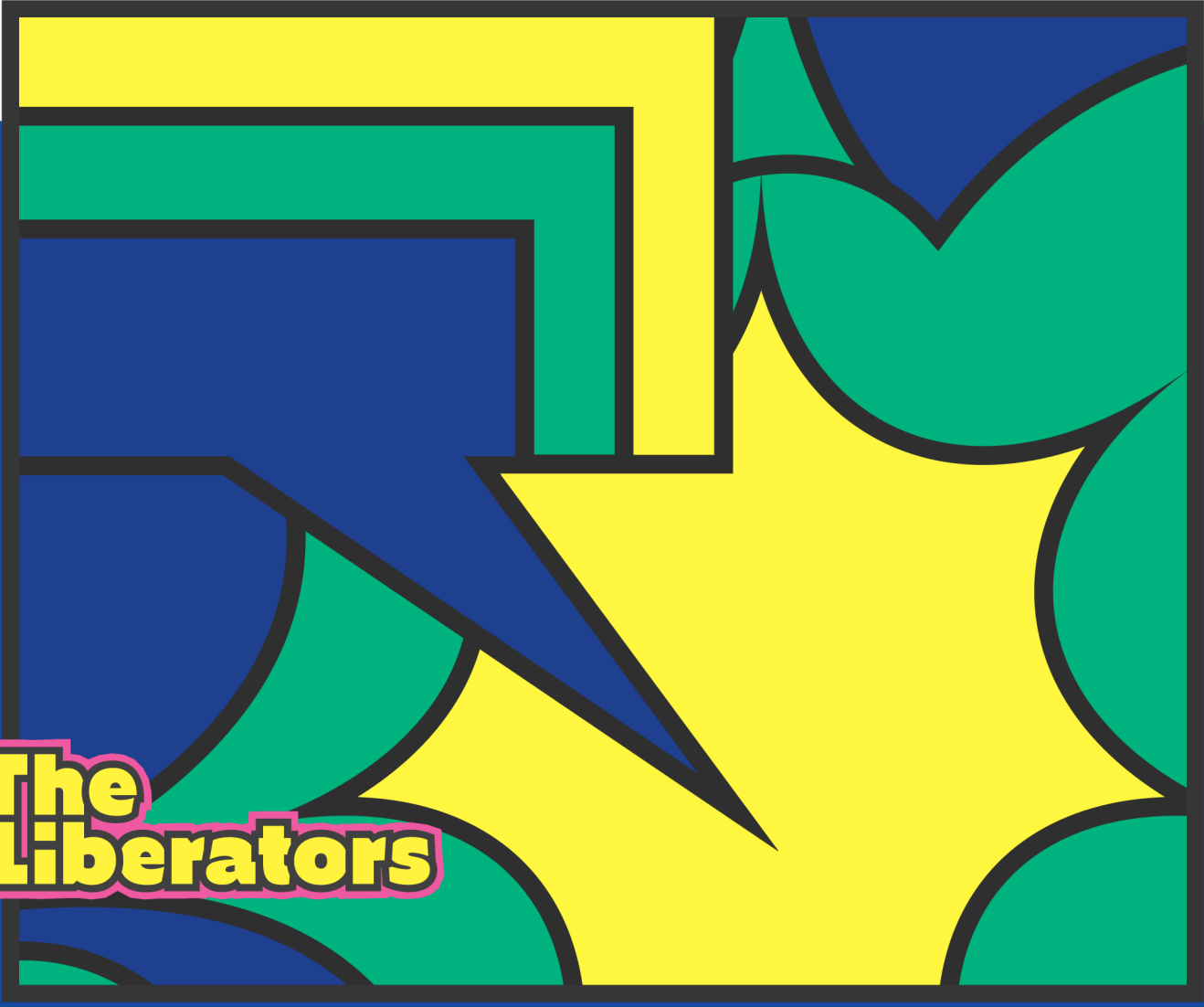


Creating Work Agreements For The Classroom

How to interactively create work agreements with students with the Liberating Structures TRIZ and 1-2-4-ALL

An abstract graphic featuring a large yellow star in the center, surrounded by green and blue shapes. The entire graphic is framed by a thick black border. The background of the page is a solid blue color.

**The
Liberators**

How to prepare



As an educator, the start of a course, class, module, or study group is a good opportunity to establish a **work agreement**. This agreement establishes how everyone can contribute to the shared learning experience. It is also a good opportunity to capture expectations.

This **exercise guide** offers two options for creating such work agreements using **liberating structures**. It is designed for:

- 5–50 students
- 30–45 minutes
- Classroom setting

To prepare:

- Optimize the learning space so students can move around and into groups easily.
- Prepare a surface to collect the outputs generated by students, like a board or a window.
- Provide pieces of paper or stickies, and pens for each student.
- To quickly regain attention at the end of the short rounds, a high tone helps cut through noise. We often use Tingsha Bells.

Attribution

This guide was created by **Barry Overeem**, **Christiaan Verwijs**, **Prof. Margaret Anne–Storey**, and **Prof. Daniel Russo**.

Liberating Structures are created by Henri Lipmanowicz and Keith McCandless. Their mission is to unleash and involve everyone. Learn more at <https://liberatingstructures.com>.



 40 min

Option 1: TRIZ



In TRIZ, students playfully imagine how they can contribute to the worst possible learning experience. Then, the exercise asks students to self-reflect and progressively identify the group agreements that help to prevent that.

Steps

- Introduce that you will be running a playful exercise to establish work agreements.
- **2 min** Ask the students to take a piece of paper. Ask: "Silently and individually make a list of everything you could personally do to guarantee a bad learning experience for yourself and this group".
- **6 min** Ask the students to form small groups (2–4) to exchange ideas and expand their individual lists with more ideas.
- **2 min** Ask the students: "Silently and individually, review your list and mark the behaviors that you already catch yourself doing every now and then."
- **6 min** Ask the students to move back into their small groups and share what they marked and what they're comfortable sharing.
- **2 min** Ask the students: "Silently and individually, write down a work agreement that we can make in this group that would help avoid this behavior in you and others".
- **6 min** Ask the students to move back into their small groups and share their ideas for work agreements.
- **10 min** Now with the entire group, collect the work agreements generated by the small groups and turn them into shared class agreements. Write them on a board.

Tips

- We find that repeating the instructions is helpful. Preface with "When I'm done explaining" to avoid people from starting moving around before you're done.
- When introducing the exercise, don't give away the halfway twist. The surprise increases impact and honesty.
- Invite students to go beyond the obvious. The more varied the ideas, the more insight you create.
- Make sure students describe their *own* behavior.
- After each small group round, you can ask for a handful of examples to spur on creativity.



 30 min

Option 2: 1-2-4-ALL



In 1-2-4-ALL, students work together to create work agreements through iterative cycles of increasing scale.

Steps

- Briefly set the stage. You will be running an interactive exercise to establish work agreements.
- **2 min** Ask the students to take a piece of paper. Ask: "Silently and individually, identify two or three work agreements that you feel this group should make to improve our learning experience".
- **4 min** Ask the students to pair up with another student to exchange their ideas and build on them.
- **8 min** Ask the pairs to join another pair into groups of four, and again exchange and build on the collective ideas. Ask the small groups to identify the two work agreements they feel are most relevant.
- **10 min** Now, with the entire group, collect the work agreements generated by the small groups and turn them into shared class agreements.

Tips

- We find that repeating the instructions is helpful. Preface with "When I'm done explaining" to avoid people starting to move around before you're done.
- When groups have already done 1-2-4-ALL before, you can reduce timeboxes to 1, 2, 4, and 10 minutes (hence the name).
- With an uneven number of participants, one "pair" of three students works fine.
- To more easily capture output for the final round, you can also give each group of four two large index cards to write down their work agreements.

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